

magnet, and some rubber bands. Of course, in terms of features and specs, the two are not even in the league. However, this just goes to illustrate that wearables can transcend barriers of price; something smartphones have successfully managed over the past five years or so.

The Birth of an Emerging Trend

The need for wearables arose from an old trend that has relented for centuries: man's need to make devices smaller and more convenient to use. Before wristwatches were invented, timekeeping devices were clunky and not known for their portability. Before you know it, wristwatches were a thing and the rest is history.

Some might say the first true wearable was the humble Bluetooth headset, devised and developed commercially around the turn of the 21st century. Of course, we could go further into the past and argue that the Pulsar Calculator Watch earned the title of the first wearable. It did qualify as an electronic device that housed a mini computer capable of performing simple calculations, while doubling up as a nifty looking wristwatch. And before all of this was the infamous computerized timing device developed by Mathematicians Edward O. Thorp, and Claude Shannon to help them cheat in games of roulette.

Back then, there wasn't really a viable market for wearable computers. In fact, the market for personal computers was slowly picking up, thanks to

the efforts of Microsoft and IBM. At this point wearables were limited to calculator watches and camera and photography-related devices. One notable device around the 80's would be the backpack-mounted wearable multimedia computer designed and built a Steve Mann. It was capable of displaying text, graphics, and multimedia including videos. Mann was an early and active researcher in the wearables field, and



A wearable MP3 player by LG